The Last Tick of the Memory Lantern

By Palak Kamthan

Hiro sat on the edge of his bed, his eyes red from crying. He had searched everywhere, but his grandmother's small wooden bird was gone. Doraemon, the round blue robotic cat from the future, sat beside him. Doraemon's soft, white paw-like hand felt steady as he patted Hiro's shoulder, trying to offer a silent kind of comfort that only a best friend can give.

"Don't cry, Hiro," Doraemon said, his voice buzzing with a soft, electronic warmth. He reached into the semi-circular white pouch on his belly. With a small chime, he pulled out a delicate paper lantern that pulsed with a soft, amber light. "This is the Memory Lantern," Doraemon explained. "It can find anything that was lost in a moment of love."

As Doraemon held the lantern high, the room filled with the scent of jasmine and old wood. A shimmering, ghostly image appeared in the air—the wooden bird was tucked deep behind the heavy bookshelf. Hiro's face lit up with a smile, but his joy faded when he noticed the lantern's light beginning to sputter and turn a pale, ghostly blue.

Suddenly, Doraemon's round body gave a sharp, mechanical jerk. His large, white eyes flickered like a dying candle, and the constant hum of his internal engine dipped into a low, mournful groan. He looked down at his white paws, which were losing their brightness and turning a dull, cold grey. Doraemon felt heavier than he ever had before.

"Doraemon? What's happening?" Hiro asked, his voice trembling with a new kind of fear. He scrambled off the bed and reached out to touch the robot's forehead. It wasn't warm like it usually was; it felt like a stone left out in the winter rain. Doraemon tried to move his mouth to speak, but the gears clicked and protested, moving in slow, painful increments.

"Every robot has a clock, Hiro," Doraemon finally whispered, his voice sounding like static on an old radio. "Mine is reaching its final tick. My battery is a gift from the future, but even the future has an end. I have to return to the Great Factory to sleep. When I wake up, I will be brand new... but the factory will wash my circuits clean. I won't remember our adventures."

Hiro panicked. He scrambled to his desk, grabbing a roll of shiny silver tape and a tube of craft glue. "I can fix you! I'll tape your clock so it can't move! I'll glue your battery shut!" He frantically began wrapping tape around Doraemon's middle, his tears falling fast and splashing onto the blue metal. He couldn't imagine a world where Doraemon didn't know his name.

Doraemon gently took Hiro's small, sticky hands in his own. "You can't stop the clock with tape, little friend," he said softly. He reached into his pouch one last time. It took a great deal of effort, but he pulled out a tiny, glowing golden seed. "This is a Courage Seed. Plant it in the garden when the world feels too quiet. It grows best when watered with memories."

The portal vanished with a soft pop, leaving the room silent and still. Doraemon was gone. Hiro stood alone by the window, clutching the golden seed tightly in his fist. Outside, the sun was setting, painting the sky in deep shades of purple and gold—the exact same colors Doraemon's eyes used to turn when he was happy. Hiro took a deep breath and looked at the garden below.